Chapter One: The Gate

“You’re late,” Mara said. The rain had not stopped since morning, and the road behind her was a river of brown water that ran all the way down to the valley.

Kai shrugged and said nothing. He had walked the whole night to get here, and his boots were full of mud. Somewhere behind the wall a bell was ringing, slow and steady.

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Chapter Two: The Road

The road ran east through the hills, past farms that had been empty for years. Nobody travelled it any more, not since the bridge went down in the spring floods.

They walked until noon without speaking, then stopped to eat under an old oak that leaned over the ditch like a tired man resting on a stick.

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